

An issue to remember

Badri Narayan, whose expertise in and passion for computer gaming is matched only by Tiger Woods for golf, is a thin man. So is Bhavesh our marketing manager, who matches Badri lost-kilo for lost-kilo. At the peak of their form, both could have been idols for the Rs 25,000-per-fashion-show ramp models. And yet, these two can gobble up food at a pace that would make a 400-pound Sumo wrestler drop his jaw. We would not have known this aspect of their personality if not for Reader Forums, a Digit exercise that, apart from understanding the culinary habits of our colleagues, also let us understand what our readers across the nation expect of us.

us to a place he claims serves the best Gujarati *thalis*. Like every marketing person making a client pitch, he is not the one to give up.

If we thought Ahmedabad was an adventure, our trip to Bangalore seemed a trek of Himalayan proportions, where he promised us a *kabab* and grilled chicken treat. His sense of taste is impeccable, but he is not exactly equipped with a global positioning system. Eight persons in three rickshaws, and only the one that had Bhavesh as navigator ended up at the wrong place! A good kilometre away from the actual destination!

Nevertheless, this delay brought to the fore the gobbling skills of Badri, who had just about an hour to go back to the guest house, pack his stuff and catch a late night flight. Sweet and noble-

ly adventurous pursuit—packing the mega December 2003 Digit issue.

Until now, we were proud of the 70,000 sq ft building that is Jasubhai Digital Media, but the combined might and space of the magazine, the six CDs (these guys didn't break even one!) and the huge cardboard box, humbled us. Every nook and cranny—the lobby, the car park, the corridors, the gym—was populated with temps who were meticulously getting packages into place so to send them all to you. Copies, all of 1,20,000 of them, were oozing out like army ants in the South American rain forests. And just in case we forgot the traffic jam when we returned to our desks, Kaizad, who some time ago betrayed the Digit editorial team to join the client marketing team, passed around a wallpaper bearing the December issue ad.

We had Digit copies coming out of our ears!

Of course, Bollywood hottie Rani Mukherjee's smiling face staring at us from cover helped us a bit. Only a bit, though.

But when the packs were despatched and readers flocked to news-stands like



A Reader Forum usually has us visiting various parts of the country where the Digit marketing and editorial teams meet up with 10 to 12 readers from each city. Over the last few months, we met readers from Ahmedabad and Bangalore, apart from Mumbai.

Bhavesh, our marketing manager, is a self-professed (stress on "self") gourmet, and claims to have unrivalled knowledge about eating joints in various cities. So in Ahmedabad, for breakfast, he ordered a kilo of *phaphda* (a local fried *papad*-like preparation) and *jalebi* for four persons. Between the four of us, a kilo of *phaphda* would have lasted days, even if we ate non-stop. We did not undertake this misadventure, and settled for omelettes and bread instead. Not discouraged by this, Bhavesh took

intentioned as he is, we have vowed not to consult Bhavesh in our future endeavours.

December Mega Issue

A few years ago, an ageing Harrison Ford and the now-I-am-lesbian-now-I-am-bisexual-oops-now-I-am-straight Anne Heche starred in a B-grade adventure flick called *Six Days Seven Nights*. We really don't know if our 200-odd temporary hands had seen the movie (our guess is, they haven't), but these guys spent the same amount as Ford and Heche, in an equal-



The Digit magazine, CDs and VCD were packed with the efficiency and precision of an assembly line

kids to a water fight, the entire Digit team—editorial, test centre, marketing, printing, logistics—went home to sleep a deep sleep. The pain was forgotten, the aching body parts ignored. With the new year peeking around the corner, it was time for smiles and much merry making.